



UC BERKELEY HAAS

INSIDER TIPS



ABOUT HAAS

As the second-oldest business school in the US, the Haas School of Business at the University of California, Berkeley has been questioning the status quo since its founding in 1898. The Berkeley Haas mission is to help extraordinary people achieve great things. At Haas, its distinctive culture is expressed through the four Defining Leadership Principles: Question the Status Quo, Confidence Without Attitude, Students Always, and Beyond Yourself. The Berkeley Haas culture fosters new thinking and new tools to change careers—and markets.

Across every dimension, Haas students, faculty, and staff are characterized by the high quality of their work, their exceptional talents and creativity, their diversity of experience, and their commitment to inclusiveness. Applicants select Berkeley Haas in order to join a diverse global community of people who use the tools of business to make a positive impact. Students work with and alongside others who embrace our Defining Leadership Principles—and see how their role is to contribute to a larger purpose.

Anchored in a rigorous general management curriculum, Haas links its courses and programs across disciplines at Berkeley and puts a premium on flexibility, allowing students to customize a program of study to their interests and design their own electives.

STRENGTHS & SPECIALIZATIONS

Entrepreneurship, General Management, Healthcare, Innovation, International Management, Nonprofit/Social Responsibility, Organizational Behavior, Research Institutes & Centers, Tech.

KEY STATS

MBA RANKINGS*	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	13	-	19	9	-	11	6	8
Financial Times	7	7	8	7	-	8	7	7
Forbes	-	14	-	8	-	9	-	11
The Economist	6	3	5	5	-	7	10	6
US News	7	7	7	7	-	7	7	6

CLASS OF 2021 ADMISSIONS

Number of Applicants	3540	Avg Age	28
MBA Class Size	283	Avg GMAT	721
Admissions selectivity	18%	Avg GPA	3.52
Yield	45%	% International	35%
Total Tuition	US\$123,0'	% Women	37%

POST-MBA CAREERS (CLASS OF 2019)

Technology	33%
Consulting	25%
Finance	15%
Consumer / Retail	10%

TOP RECRUITERS INCLUDE:

Adobe, Amazon, Bain & Company, EY-Parthenon, BCG, Cisco, Deloitte, The Clorox Company, Google, L.E.K. Consulting, McKinsey, PwC, Visa

AVERAGE BASE SALARY: US\$137,819

EMPLOYED IN 3 MONTHS: 93%

*Rankings are relative to other U.S. business schools. [Read more](#) about the Fortuna ranking methodology.



TOP TIPS FOR ACING YOUR HAAS APPLICATION

BY SHARON JOYCE

With over 25 years of experience in admissions and student affairs, Sharon is a seasoned professional in higher education who has been lauded for her innovative approaches in streamlining interview processes at multiple institutions and her efforts to create inclusive communities in graduate education. At UC Berkeley's Haas School of Business, she served as the Associate Director of Admissions for the full-time program MBA program, while also collaborating on the overall strategic plan for Haas admissions as a member of the Senior Management team.



Through the essays, the Admissions Committee is seeking to uncover the less visible forces that shape candidates' lives, opportunities, decisions, and character.

1

THE FOUR LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES ARE A REAL THING

The four principles – Question the Status Quo, Confidence Without Attitude, Students Always, and Beyond Yourself – are truly reflective of the school’s culture and not just marketing fodder. Prepare to demonstrate how and why these principles speak to you. In the Haas interview, for example, you may be asked which one resonates most. There isn’t a right or wrong reply to this and it’s not a trick, but your ability to be authentic and honest in response depends on whether you’ve taken the time to get introspective about both the principles and your fit with the program.

DIVERSITY OF CULTURES AND PERSPECTIVES IS PARAMOUNT

2

The school is committed to recruiting the most diverse students, faculty, and staff to enhance the mission, community, and academic excellence. Through the essays, the Admissions Committee is seeking to uncover the less visible forces that shape candidates’ lives, opportunities, decisions, and character. Express your values, political engagement, awareness of social justice, and/or access to education in terms of social mobility – all of which are very important to Haas. This school seeks students who demonstrate self-awareness and community engagement, which is an invitation to recognize your privilege and convey a deep understanding of what that means to you. Haas genuinely fosters a climate of inclusion, empathy, and compassion. Even if you don’t identify as a member of a marginalized group, it can be valuable to show how you are an ally and welcoming of different ways of thinking, which ties to Questioning the Status Quo and Beyond Yourself.

3

PRIDE IN BEING PART OF A WORLD-RECOGNIZED PUBLIC INSTITUTION

It's important to demonstrate some awareness that Berkeley Haas is part of the University of California system, with Berkeley being its flagship campus. The University of California was founded in 1868, born out of a vision in the State Constitution of a university that would "contribute even more than California's gold to the glory and happiness of advancing generations." UC Berkeley students – Haas students included – are reputed to be "scrappier" than peers at private institutions as well as lauded by recruiters for being less "entitled," which ties directly to the Confidence Without Attitude principle.

IT'S OKAY TO BE A LITTLE BIT "BEZERKELEY"

4

The term "Beserkeley" has a history in popular culture and media lingo. In 2004, the current top definition for the word "Bezerkeley," a popular spelling variant of the word, was created on Urban Dictionary. The word as read on the site is defined simply as "Berkeley, California," as if the name of the city alone were enough to express the out-there atmosphere associated with the locale. How does this apply to Berkeley Haas? The Admissions Committee does place some value on being a bit quirky – if this is authentically who you are. (But don't fake it if you're not!) The acceptance of those who might have taken a path less traveled, or who have an unusual talent or hobby, is what makes the Haas student body so unique. The essay prompts tend to be less conventional by design; the admissions committee wants to find out what makes you tick, up and beyond your work and academic acumen. You should approach the prompts with enthusiasm, gusto and as a signal of your fit for the program.

5

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT IS REQUISITE

The student-driven and deeply participatory atmosphere at Haas is another vital differentiator to connect to your narrative. Haas's culture of engagement extends beyond studies into institutional operations, with feedback loops between student government and every administrative function/office within the program. Student viewpoints are taken very seriously and are actively solicited. Admissions interviews are predominately conducted by student interviewers, for example, and their reviews of candidates are weighed equally to those conducted by alumni and professional staff.

As such, if you're among the fortunate to be invited to interview, know that current students, who serve as interviewers, can be tough evaluators. You will need to cite two-to-three clubs you plan to join at Haas, as well as link at least one club with experience or position you've served in the past to demonstrate your commitment, sincerity and track record of community engagement. So earlier on in the application process, be sure to reach out to student leadership to have a few examples of how you'll be an active participant.

ESSAY ANALYSIS

In addition to considering a candidate's academic and professional background in the admissions process, Haas places a strong emphasis on personal characteristics and is looking for students who will be involved in the school and community.



ESSAY 1. What makes you feel alive when you are doing it, and why? (300 words)

I love the wording of this question – any opportunity to learn about what ignites the spark in a candidate is really exciting to read. This question also underscores that Haas is looking for people who will actively contribute to the community and beyond, not just in the classroom. Your intellectual acumen and accomplishments a given, what are you passionate about and why does it ignite that aliveness in you? This essay prompt allows the admissions team to understand ‘what makes you tick’ up and beyond what they’ll glean from your academic record and work history.

Given that you only have 300 words, the maxim to ‘show not tell’ is critical here. You want to bring the reader on the experience with you so they can smell, taste, feel and connect to whatever it is you’re describing – what it felt like to summit that mountaintop and peer into the volcano’s smoky belly, or the felt experience in a devotional act of creation that erased any sense of time. And unless it’s deeply sincere and will ring true, a community service moment or tutoring exchange isn’t necessarily the place to shine the spotlight. Dig deep and dare to have a little fun here; your voice can convey your personality.

ESSAY 2. The definition of successful leadership has evolved over the last decade and will continue to change. What do you need to develop to become a successful leader? (300 words)

The ambiguous nature of this question is a purposeful contrast to last year’s framing, which established that Haas is ‘redefining leadership’ and

went on to articulate its value proposition as a set up to inquire 'how a Haas MBA would enhance your leadership profile.' This year, instead of explicitly stating what Haas values and cares most about (although note that is still reflected in the intro to all essays), Haas invites you to articulate your values around leadership within the context of what you're hoping to develop (with - unstated but implicit here - a Haas MBA).

The set up to this question, and its reference to the last 10 years, is subtle but important - in citing that 'the definition of successful leadership has evolved over the last decade and will continue to change,' Haas signals that traits such as flexibility, growth mindset, and inclusivity are at a premium. Those who are being successful right now are comfortable navigating in a sea of uncertainty and prepared to adapt to the changing times.

It's a reflective piece, and again, you have only 300 words to convey your point. You'll want to speak with precision and authenticity about ways you're hoping to enhance your leadership profile. Approach this with some humility in thinking about leadership. Has there ever been something you'd have pushed more successfully over the finish line if you had X or Y under your belt? Or an instance where you sense your impact could have been much greater with the benefit of Z? Not necessarily something transactional, but something more experiential or that you'd gain in a relational context? If you think of the MBA experience as a huge learning laboratory, what might you want to perfect over the last few years that will set you up for success? In doing so, how can you convey a nuanced understanding of what it means to be a successful leader?

ESSAY 3. (OPTIONAL) In addition to the two required essays, candidates who wish to tell us about how they have responded to hardships or unusual life circumstances are encouraged to complete the optional essay. This information will provide context to your opportunities & achievements and contribute to our holistic review of your application. (See full question on Haas website).

While this section is lightly rephrased from last year's (pay special attention to the introduction to these essays), the spirit behind the asking is the same: to hone in on the path that students walked to better understand who they're reading. In Optional essay 1, Haas seeks to uncover the less visible forces that shape candidates' lives, opportunities, decisions, and character. This includes the challenges certain applicants face to get to where they are – even when students themselves don't see them as distinctive or noteworthy.

Socioeconomic barriers, for example, can contribute to things that might be missing from an application but, in context, convey bigger picture understanding. It's a recognition from Haas of the huge range of students applying to business school, and a desire to support the admissions committee's decision-making by supplying a full and rich understanding of who each applicant truly is and the circumstances that shaped their lives. You'll do well not to consider the first question optional, while avoiding the second unless you have something truly relevant to add that isn't elsewhere addressed.

DEADLINES & DATES

	APPLICATION DEADLINE	DECISION NOTIFICATION
1st Deadline	24 September 2020	17 December 2020
2nd Deadline	14 January 2021	25 March 2021
3rd Deadline	5 April 2021	13 May 2021



**The best time to
apply is when you're
ready.**

Caroline Diarte Edwards,
Co-Founder & Director of Fortuna Admissions

LET'S GET YOU IN.

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Yale SOM, Cornell Johnson and Berkeley Haas.

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